only in 2005, on the 600th anniversary of the first Zheng He voyage, that a full-scale propaganda campaign was launched, reaffirming China's history as a major naval power, but one engaged in a peaceful and non-hegemonic way with the Indian Ocean world. The eleventh of July was henceforth observed as Maritime Day. The site of the Nanjing dockyards was developed into a museum focused on Zheng He's voyages, and television serials were broadcast on the theme. This focus has been sustained and even reinforced since then.

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This 'maritime rebranding' has multiple objectives:

To reorient public consciousness seawards and instil pride in China's maritime legacy using the Zheng He story, suitably adjusted, to legitimize the expansion of China's maritime power.

To project Zheng He's voyages as an exercise in peaceful, friendly exchanges, unlike the Western colonial aggression and occupation in Asia and Africa. On a visit to South Africa in 2007, the Chinese President of the time, Hu Jintao, claimed that Zheng He 'brought to the African people a message of peace and goodwill, not swords, not guns, plunder or slavery'. The parallel with a benign PRC is obvious.

To buttress Chinese 'historic rights' to the entire maritime space of the South China Sea. This is the hard-power use of the Zheng He legacy.

The Travels of Ibn Battuta, translated by Rev Samuel Lee, 1829, Pan Macmillan, 2003.

The Yuanshi [History of the Yuan Dynasty], Zhonghua, 1976, p. 4669.

The word 'junk' is an old Javanese term dating back to the ninth century; it used to describe Chinese merchant ships.

Henry Mieres Elliot and John Dawson, History of India, as Told by Its Own Historians (8 volumes), Trubner, 1867–77.

'Civilizational Rhetoric and the Obfuscation of Power Politics' by Yuan-kang Wang, Geoff Wade and Liam Kelly in Sacred Mandates, eds.,Timothy Brook, Michael van Walt van Praag and Miek Boltjes, University of Chicago Press, 2018.

From a tablet erected by Zheng He in Changle, Fujian in 1432. Cited in When China Ruled the Seas: The Treasure Fleet of the Dragon Throne, 1405–1433, Oxford University Press, 1997.